

PRIMAL — Bestiary (v1, playtest reference)

You are not the only thing that hunts here. Everything in this forest has learned to stay alive. Learn what it does before it teaches you.

How to read this file

Every entry has the same shape so it drops cleanly into code and into the in-game bestiary panel (button under the pouch/instincts inventory).

- **Flavor** — the italic line shown at the top of the bestiary entry. Tone: eerie, sparse, night-vision forest.
- **Stats** — HP, starting/max Breath, tier. **All numbers are PROVISIONAL** — tune them against the Dominance meter once it's in, not before.
- **Moveset** — every action the animal can schedule. Costs are enemy Breath.
- **Tells (×2)** — the two learnable quirks. This is the heart of the entry: a skilled player picks these up by playing; an experienced one checks here. Each tell is something the player can *act on*.
- **Read profile** — how the animal's hidden state tends to behave (skittish-first, calm-heavy, etc.) so its Observe reads feel distinct.

Baked-in rules from your latest pass (marked ★ where they appear):

- Wolf: **Bite** move; blocking a wolf attack makes it less likely to attack next turn; more aggressive when player is low on Breath.
- Lynx: more aggressive when player is low on Breath.
- Greater Stag / Dire Wolf / Bear: **stay Calm at low HP** (cornered-apex — harder to read when nearly dead).
- Razorback / Bear: **+1 damage below 40% HP** (enraged).
- Greater Stag: has both a Light Attack and its Heavy (Gore).

Shared move vocabulary (for reference): Light Attack (1 Breath / 1 dmg) · Heavy/Claw (2 / 2) · Guard (1 / -1 dmg) · Dodge (2 / negate) · Rest (+3 Breath) · Feint (appears aggressive, gains Breath — higher tiers only).

△ **Roster note:** this is reconstructed from the design doc plus the animals you've named in playtesting (razorback, lynx, greater stag, dire wolf). Send me your actual current roster and I'll align names / fill gaps. Bosses are stubbed at the end — they need bespoke design and you said they come later.

EARLY PREY

Rabbit

It is already looking for the way out. It was looking before you arrived.

- **Stats:** 2 HP · 3/4 Breath · Tier: Early
- **Moveset:** Light Attack (1/1, rare) · Dodge (2) · Rest · **Bolt** (special: attempts to flee; if it survives 2 more turns it escapes and you lose the Blood)
- **Tells:**
 1. **Almost never commits.** Opens Skittish and stays there — it dodges and rests, it does not fight. A wasted Claw into its Dodge is how you lose the kill.
 2. **It runs.** Below half HP it will try to Bolt. Pressure it fast or it's gone with your Blood.
- **Read profile:** Skittish-first, almost no Calm. The easiest read in the forest — and the easiest Blood to lose.

Deer

Soft-eyed. Watching the treeline, not you. That is a kind of mistake.

- **Stats:** 3 HP · 3/4 Breath · Tier: Early
- **Moveset:** Light Attack (1/1) · Guard (1) · Dodge (2) · Rest
- **Tells:**
 1. **Won't strike first.** Opens Skittish; only turns Aggressive if cornered or pressed several turns running. Safe to open aggressive against it.
 2. **Falls into a rhythm** — tends to alternate defend / light attack. Two Observes and you've got the pattern.
- **Read profile:** Skittish-heavy, low Calm. Your teaching fight.

Young Buck

Younger. Angrier. Hasn't learned yet what the dark costs.

- **Stats:** 4 HP · 3/4 Breath · Tier: Early
- **Moveset:** Light Attack (1/1) · **Gore** (2/2, telegraphed) · Guard (1) · Rest
- **Tells:**

1. **Overextends.** Leads with light attacks and presses even when it shouldn't — then runs dry. After ~2 attacks it *must* Rest. That Rest is your free window.
 2. **Winds up.** Its Gore is telegraphed by a Calm "set" turn — read the wind-up, punish the exhaustion.
- **Read profile:** Aggressive-leaning for prey, spikes of Calm before the Gore.

Boar Piglet

Small, low to the ground, and utterly convinced it is dangerous.

- **Stats:** 3 HP · 2/4 Breath · Tier: Early
 - **Moveset:** Light Attack (1/1) · **Charge** (2/2) · Rest
 - **Tells:**
 1. **Reckless — no self-preservation.** Attacks into bad odds. Rarely defends, so raw aggression works, but it *will* trade blows with you.
 2. **Tiny lungs.** Lowest Breath pool in the early tier; tires after two actions. Outlast it.
 - **Read profile:** Aggressive-first, almost no defensive reads.
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MID

Razorback ★

The tusks came in. So did the memory of every time something bigger won.

- **Stats:** 6 HP · 3/5 Breath · Tier: Mid
- **Moveset:** **Gore** (2/2) · **Charge** (3/3, telegraphed heavy) · Guard (1) · Rest
- **Tells:**
 1. **Enraged when wounded ★** — below 40% HP its attacks deal +1. Finishing it is more dangerous than starting it; don't get sloppy on the last hit.
 2. **The Charge announces itself** — a Calm wind-up turn precedes it. Read the set, Dodge the Charge, punish the recovery.
- **Read profile:** Aggressive, with a Calm "tell" before the big hit. Reads shift *toward* danger as its HP drops.

Ram

It has spent its whole life measuring the distance to the next thing it will hit.

- **Stats:** 6 HP · 3/5 Breath · Tier: Mid

- **Moveset:** Headbutt (2/2) · Guard (1) · Rest
- **Tells:**
 1. **Momentum killer.** If a Headbutt lands *unblocked*, its next Headbutt costs 1 less Breath — so it chains. Block the FIRST one and the chain never starts.
 2. **Patient wall.** Guards a lot and waits; it won't overcommit. You have to make the opening, it won't hand you one.
- **Read profile:** Defensive-heavy, low Aggression until it smells a chain.

Fox

It is not afraid. It is deciding what you are worth.

- **Stats:** 4 HP · 4/5 Breath · Tier: Mid
- **Moveset:** Light Attack (1/1) · **Feint** (appears Aggressive, gains Breath) · Dodge (2) · Rest
- **Tells:**
 1. **The forest's first liar.** Uses Feint even at this tier — a Calm state can read Aggressive. Your first taste of an unreliable read; don't trust one Observe against it.
 2. **Dodges your heavies.** It reads your commitment and slips Claws. Bait it with a light attack, or make it guess.
- **Read profile:** Calm-heavy, deceptive. The animal that teaches you Observe isn't gospel.

Coyote / Wild Dog

Where there is one set of eyes in the dark, assume there were others a moment ago.

- **Stats:** 5 HP · 4/5 Breath · Tier: Mid
- **Moveset:** Light Attack (1/1) · **Harry** (1/1, cheap harassment) · Dodge (2) · Rest
- **Tells:**
 1. **Opportunist.** More likely to attack the turn you're low on Breath. Don't bottom out your Breath in front of it — it's waiting for exactly that.
 2. **Harasses, rarely commits.** Chips with cheap light attacks instead of big swings. Wears down your Dominance more than your HP if you let it dictate tempo.
- **Read profile:** Aggressive when you're weak, Skittish when you're strong — it reads the room.

Lynx ★

The branch above you has been empty for a long time. You are fairly sure it was empty.

- **Stats:** 5 HP · 4/5 Breath · Tier: Mid

- **Moveset:** **Ambush** (first strike only: 2/3, bonus damage opener) · Light Attack (1/1) · Dodge (2) · Rest
 - **Tells:**
 1. **Opens with an Ambush.** Its first action each fight is a heavy strike from hiding — expect aggression turn one and be ready to Dodge it, or eat the worst hit of the fight.
 2. **Presses your weakness ★** — more aggressive when you're low on Breath. Same trap as the coyote, harder teeth.
 - **Read profile:** Aggressive-first (the Ambush), then shifts to patient/Calm repositioning.
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LATE / APEX

Wolf ★

It is not in a hurry. It has already decided how this ends. It is only waiting for you to agree.

- **Stats:** 7 HP · 4/6 Breath · Tier: Late
- **Moveset:** Light Attack (1/1) · Claw (2/2) · **Bite ★** (2/2 — but **1 Breath if it connects unblocked, 3 Breath if defended**) · Guard (1) · Feint · Rest
- **Tells:**
 1. **Blocking crushes its tempo ★** — successfully blocking a wolf attack makes it less likely to attack next turn. A clean block isn't just defense against a wolf; it's an *opening*.
 2. **Hunts weakness ★** — more aggressive when you're low on Breath, and the Bite is its punish: cheap if it lands raw, expensive if you block it. So the Bite is a bet on your read. Read it → block it → drain its Breath. Miss the read → it barely paid for a 2-hit.
- **Read profile:** Calm-heavy for its tier, feints mixed in. The wolf wants you to guess wrong.

Mountain Lion

It watched you win the last three fights. It was not impressed. It was taking notes.

- **Stats:** 8 HP · 4/6 Breath · Tier: Late
- **Moveset:** **Pounce** (first strike: 3/3 heavy opener) · Claw (2/2) · **Reposition** (defensive special: resets to a Calm "stalking" state) · Dodge (2) · Rest
- **Tells:**

1. **Pounce opener.** Like the lynx but heavier — turn one is a committed strike. Survive the open and you've weathered its best.
 2. **Repositions to reset.** Mid-fight it breaks off into a Calm stalking state, then re-engages with a fresh Pounce. A Calm read from a Mountain Lion is not safety — it's the wind-up.
- **Read profile:** Bursts of Aggression around long Calm stretches. Punish the exhaustion after a Pounce.

Dire Wolf ★

The pack had a leader before this one. It does not.

- **Stats:** 9 HP · 5/7 Breath · Tier: Late (elite)
- **Moveset:** Claw (2/2) · **Bite** (2/2, 1 if unblocked / 3 if defended) · **Feint** · Guard (1) · Rest
- **Tells:**
 1. **Calm when cornered ★** — unlike lesser prey, it does NOT get twitchy at low HP; it goes Calm and unreadable. The kill is the hardest read of the fight. This is the trait that punishes players who autopilot the finisher.
 2. **Reads you back** (*pending — the two-way-read mechanic*) — if you fall into a predictable rhythm it starts anticipating and defending your attacks. Vary your cadence. (*Flag this off until the enemy-memory system exists; listed here so the design is on record.*)
- **Read profile:** Deceptive and Calm-heavy, worst exactly when it's nearly dead.

Bear ★

Everything else in the forest moves out of its way. You are about to explain why.

- **Stats:** 12 HP · 4/6 Breath · Tier: Late (apex)
- **Moveset:** **Swipe** (3/3, telegraphed) · **Maul** (special heavy) · Guard (1) · Rest
- **Tells:**
 1. **Calm when cornered ★ + enraged when wounded ★** — below 40% HP it stays Calm (unreadable) AND deals +1. The most dangerous phase of the fight is the phase you thought was the victory lap. Save a full-mitigation option (Dodge / Bone Charm) for the finish.
 2. **Telegraphed but devastating.** The Swipe winds up on a Calm turn — you *can* read it — but eating one raw is 3 damage, more than half your base HP. Reading the wind-up isn't optional against a bear; it's survival.
- **Read profile:** Slow, Calm-heavy, brutal on contact. A patience fight — bleed its Breath, punish the Rests, respect the finish.

Moose / Elk

It is bigger than it has any right to be, and it knows the ground better than you do.

- **Stats:** 10 HP · 4/6 Breath · Tier: Late
- **Moveset:** **Charge** (3/3, long reach, telegraphed) · **Trample** (heavy) · Guard (1) · Rest
- **Tells:**
 1. **Reach.** Its Charge is a committed telegraph — read the set, get out of the way, and the recovery window is huge because the move costs it so much Breath.
 2. **Defensive until provoked.** Mostly Calm/Guarding; it doesn't want the fight. But repeated pressure flips it Aggressive fast — decide whether you're finishing it or leaving it be.
- **Read profile:** Calm/defensive, with rare committed heavies. A long fight; watch your own Breath.

Greater Stag ★

The antlers have counted more winters than you will. It is not frightened of the dark. It is the reason other things are.

- **Stats:** 11 HP · 5/7 Breath · Tier: Late (lesser-boss feel)
- **Moveset:** **Light Attack** ★ (1/1) · **Gore** ★ (2/2, its heavy) · Guard (1) · Dodge (2) · Feint · Rest
- **Tells:**
 1. **Full kit** ★ — unlike lesser deer it has BOTH a light attack and its Gore, plus a Dodge and a Feint. It plays a real game: it varies pace, it lies, it defends. Treat it like a fight, not a hunt.
 2. **Calm when cornered** ★ — regal and unreadable at low HP. Combined with its Feint, the endgame is a genuine guessing match. This is the fight that tells you whether the player is ready for bosses.
- **Read profile:** Balanced and deceptive — the most "complete" non-boss in the forest.

BOSSES (*stubs — bespoke design is a later pass*)

Bosses should feel more grounded early (per your doc) and escalate into the mythic. Each needs a unique mechanic, not just bigger stats. One-line identities to build from later:

- **Ancient Stag** — the Greater Stag's fight, but it *learns your patterns within the fight* (early home for the enemy-reads-you-back mechanic).

- **Alpha Wolf** — arrives with pack-pressure: periodic off-turn harassment that taxes your Breath economy, forcing you to fight the clock as well as the wolf.
 - **Giant Bear** — the wounded-apex trait dialed to a phase mechanic: below a threshold it becomes Calm, enraged, and stops telegraphing. A survival check.
 - **The White Predator** — pure deception: most reads are Feints; the fight is about trusting behavior over Observe.
 - **Forest Warden** — a control fight built around battle modifiers it imposes on you turn to turn; the environment is the boss.
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Send your current roster and I'll reconcile names, fill anything missing, and lock the provisional stats to the Dominance economy once it's in.